

Travelling with Arthritis – UK & Abroad Guide

Planning a holiday with arthritis? UK guide to travel insurance, accessible accommodation, flying tips, medication management, and making the most of your trip.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-01 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis doesn't have to stop you travelling. With proper planning, you can enjoy holidays in the UK and abroad. This guide covers everything from travel insurance to managing medications while away.

Before You Go

Travel Insurance

Standard travel insurance may not cover pre-existing conditions like arthritis. You need to:

- Declare arthritis when buying travel insurance
- Specialist providers: AllClear, InsureWith, Avanti, Staysure
- Cover should include emergency treatment for flare-ups abroad
- GHIC (Global Health Insurance Card) provides access to state healthcare in EU countries — apply free at nhs.uk

Medications

- Carry medications in original packaging with prescription labels
 - Take enough for your trip plus a few extra days
 - Keep medications in hand luggage (never checked luggage)
 - Carry a letter from your GP listing your medications — especially for controlled drugs or injectable biologics
 - Check destination country rules on medication imports
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Flying with Arthritis



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- Request assistance — airports provide free assistance from check-in to the gate (book 48 hours ahead)
- Aisle seat — easier to get up and move during the flight
- Move regularly — walk the aisle every 30-60 minutes to prevent stiffness
- Compression socks — reduce swelling on long flights
- Support pillows — neck and lumbar pillows for comfort
- Stay hydrated — cabin air is very dry
- Time medication — adjust for time zones on long-haul flights

Accessible Accommodation

- Look for ground-floor rooms or properties with lifts
 - Check for walk-in showers (no bath step-over)
 - UK: search "accessible holiday cottages" on DisabledHolidays.com or AccessAble
 - Hotels: Travelodge accessible rooms are reliably equipped
 - Cruise ships: often excellent for accessibility
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UK Accessible Breaks



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- Calvert Trust — accessible activity holidays in Exmoor, Lake District, Kielder

- Center Parcs — adapted lodges and accessible facilities
 - National Trust — many properties have accessibility guides on their website
 - Seaside towns — many have beach wheelchairs available
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During Your Trip

- Pace yourself — don't try to pack every day full of activities
- Build in rest days
- Carry a fold-up walking stick or portable seat for queues
- Apply for a RADAR key (£5 from Disability Rights UK) — opens 10,000+ accessible toilets across the UK
- Keep a cool bag for biologic medications if they need refrigeration

Don't let arthritis stop you exploring. With the right preparation, you can travel comfortably and create wonderful memories.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about travelling with arthritis – uk & abroad guide?

Short answer: When travelling with arthritis, declare your condition for travel insurance and carry medications in hand luggage with a GP letter. Request airport assistance, reserve an aisle seat, and move frequently during flights. Choose accessible accommodation, such as ground-floor rooms or those with lifts and walk-in showers. Pace yourself, use a fold-up walking stick, and consider a RADAR key for accessible toilets.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk